

Blacksburg Museum and Cultural Foundation Organizational Report

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Blacksburg Museum and Cultural Foundation
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Diana Francis,

Thank you for your time, it was a pleasure to meet with you. We are sending you this to provide you with our Organization Report. At your convenience, please review this and let us know if you have any feedback. We want to ensure that we are accurately portraying the mission and values of the Blacksburg Museum and Cultural Foundation.

Please let us know if you have any questions or information you would like included. We hope you are having a wonderful week.

Best,

Hayley Bisek, Riley Bump, Kaitlyn Ellis, and Lucia Lorenz

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History

The Blacksburg Museum and Cultural Foundation is a 501(c)(3) nonprofit organization that began in the Alexander Black House, which was built by Alexander Black, the great, great nephew of the founder of Blacksburg, in 1896. After passing away in 1935, the house became a boarding home and then eventually housed many different funeral homes. To save the house from demolition, the Town of Blacksburg bought it in 2002 and moved its location. It was vacant for a while before eventually enough funds were raised to begin the first phase of restoration. In 2013, Glavé & Holmes Architecture restored the exterior of the building to its late-nineteenth-century appearance and made the necessary changes to the interior for it to be a museum and exhibit. The Town of Blacksburg decided to form the Blacksburg Museum and Cultural Foundation to run the museum and in August of 2014, it officially opened its doors to the public.

Since then, the museum has housed numerous different events, programs, services, and collections to display Blacksburg history. These include:

- Rotating exhibits of art, history & culture
- Community gathering spaces
- Museum archives & collections
- Children's Room
- Executive offices of the Blacksburg Museum & Cultural Foundation
- Gift Shop that promotes local artists
- History & Genealogy Research Center
- Permanent exhibit of Blacksburg's history
- Permanent "period display" & exhibit in the Alexander Black Bedroom
- Annual community events such as the "Blues, Brews & BBQ" Festival
- Permanent outdoor sculpture exhibit
- Education & Workshop Room

Mission

The Blacksburg Museum and Cultural Foundation's main mission is to preserve Blacksburg history, culture, and art all while strengthening the Blacksburg community. By preserving and restoring historic landmarks, buildings, streets, the Blacksburg Museum and Cultural Foundation is able to inform locals and bring awareness to the rich history of Blacksburg and what it means to be standing here today. The museum aims to get more town residents involved in the acknowledgment and knowledge of Blacksburg history so they may better understand the significance of the stones they walk on, streets they live on, and buildings they pass by each day.

In learning about the history of Blacksburg, the Blacksburg Museum and Cultural Foundation helps bring significance to the lives of all who live and have lived here. They want people to

understand the triumph and the suffering that was endured in Blacksburg throughout history and to provide a stronger sense of community for both generational families and newcomers.

Focusing on culture, issues like civil rights and slavery are a big focus for the Blacksburg Museum and Cultural Foundation, especially when it comes to preserving certain neighborhoods and streets that hold that history. Many of the stories and buildings, once full of rich history, have been left to decay and be forgotten. The Blacksburg Museum and Cultural Foundation aims to make sure that doesn't happen and bring light to such a dark history.

The arts provide an outlet for expression, one seen in Blacksburg history since the beginning. Town hall dances and art galleries continue to be provided by the Blacksburg Museum and Cultural Foundation in order to both acknowledge the talent within the community and remember dances and galleries generations before.

Values

The Blacksburg Museum and Cultural Foundation values history, culture, art, and community.

By valuing history, the people of Blacksburg are able to understand their identity, learn from the past, preserve culture, and pave a way for the future.

Valuing culture allows the people of Blacksburg to emphasize diversity and inclusion within their community, preserve the identity that's understood from history, promote creativity and expression, and encourage understanding among society.

Art is the value that promotes freedom and innovation. It aligns with the importance of creativity and gives Blacksburg an outlet for their preservation of the history and culture around them.

Aligned with their mission, their values provide a stepping stone for how they operate and what they focus on in their work. This includes rotating art and history exhibits, paying homage to historical funeral homes, the 16 squares exhibit which exemplifies the foundation of Blacksburg itself, and restoring historical landmark St. Luke & Odd Fellows Hall, the social hall for African Americans from 1905 to the end of segregation, to eventually be turned into an exhibit highlighting Blacksburg African American history.

Staff

Diana Francis - Executive Director

A Blacksburg resident since 1994, Diana is the Executive Director of the Blacksburg Museum and Cultural Foundation. She has a Bachelor of Arts (BA), English and a Communications Minor concentrated on Film Studies degree that she acquired from Virginia Tech. She also has a Master of Arts in Education (M.A.Ed.), Teaching and Learning degree from Virginia Tech as well. Diana is the co-founder of The Artful Lawyer, A Fine Gallery Incorporation and was the General Manager for eight years before coming to the Blacksburg Museum and Cultural

Foundation. She first started working as part-time management at the museum in July of 2023 before becoming the director in October of 2024.

Richard Baldwin - Museum Assistant

Richard has been a resident of Blacksburg since 2013 when he moved here to pursue a degree at Virginia Tech. He graduated with a Bachelor of Arts (BA), Political Science degree and continued to work and live in Blacksburg after. Fascinated with history, Richard plans to continue learning about the history of Blacksburg and implement his skills in order to carry out their mission.

Aliza Qureshi - Museum Assistant

Fifth-year undergraduate student, Aliza Qureshi, aims to graduate with a Bachelor of Architecture and minor in Art History. Her passion for the museum and history stem from her love of culture and architecture which ignited when living in Dubai, UAE, for four years. She also studied abroad at Temple University in Tokyo, Japan, which helped widen her knowledge of culture.

Finances

The Blacksburg Museum and Cultural Foundation, receives consistent funding from the township of Blacksburg. This town funding, however, is limited to only fund lawn maintenance, house maintenance, and paying the employees of the foundation. The amount of money they receive from the town can vary depending on how much community engagement and participation they get at community events they hold throughout the year. Although this is the only guaranteed funding they receive every year, below are community events and other sources that provide funding to this foundation:

- Football Game Parking/Concert Parking: The convenience of this foundation being located right next to the Virginia Tech campus allows them to use their three lots to provide parking for games and concerts held at Lane Stadium. They sell parking memberships that can last the whole season, costing \$280 each, bringing in consistent funding every year. The total amount they have earned from 2024 is currently \$4,000.
- Artist Commission Splits: The museum hosts many exhibits each year that showcase artists' works. Contracts are written up that require a 30% commission on the art sold at the museum. This can be seen as a service charge for advertising and marketing the artist and their individual artwork.
- Community Events: There are two major community events that this foundation holds. These include events such as Genealogy Saturdays, Haunted House, Lecture Series, 16 Square tours, and the Market Jam. These events bring in people who make donations to the museum.

- Memberships: The museum sells memberships that range from \$30 to \$1,000 each, depending on the membership package you receive. Currently, this year they have sold 90 memberships.

Below is a detailed breakdown of the total revenue earned in the past years, 2023 and 2022:

Revenues	Year 2023	Year 2022
Total grants, contributions, etc.	\$161,200.00	\$200,981.00
Program services	\$2,926.00	\$3,608.00
Investment income and dividends	\$20.00	\$3.00
Net income from fundraising events	\$34,719.00	\$42,562.00
Total revenues	\$198,865.00	\$247,154.00

Community Need

The Blacksburg Museum and Cultural Foundation was created to honor the long history of the Blacksburg area and to facilitate a location of cultural reflection and growth. The museum benefits both the local community and the student population nearby, hosting community events and educating the locals, those new to town, and those stopping by on visits to the university.

St. Luke & Odd Fellows Hall

The current need for funds and growth addresses St. Luke & Odd Fellows Hall, to complete the interior restoration of the historic site and create museum exhibits of a more interactive nature.

St. Luke & Odd Fellows Hall is the last remaining piece of New Town, the African American town adjacent to Blacksburg established after the Civil War. Renovations are now in progress to make St. Luke & Odd Fellows Hall look more obviously like a historic attraction from the street, but the Blacksburg Museum and Cultural Foundation is still looking for funds and options for the interior of the building, where actual exhibits and events will be held. The museum's previous renovation increased the occupancy from 25 to 45 people, allowing the future exhibit to host larger events and draw more visitors in for the exhibits.

The St. Luke & Odd Fellows Hall is in need of funds for signage and exhibits. The building has recently been renovated and is in need of interactive elements that pay proper respect to the history of the location and people. This building is a crucial historic site, as it is the last standing building of New Town, which was the home of a segregated community during the post Civil War era. St. Luke & Odd Fellows Hall served as the center of this segregated community during this time as a dance hall, funeral center, and community meeting place. One interactive exhibit element the museum wants to bring to life is to have recordings of the former residents of New

Town telling the story of their experiences with the building and townspeople, which would play by associated artefacts and history boards when activated.

The building is currently marked with only a small historic marker. There is a vast visual difference between how the surrounding area used to look and now, with roads and buildings dwarfing the house. It's easy to walk by and have no idea that the building is even there, or that it played such a large role and served so many. To draw attention to the house as a historic location and draw in more people, the museum intends to build permanent signage that draws the eye to the house and marks it as a significant historic location within the town of Blacksburg.

To facilitate more interactive exhibits and increase the museum's reach, the museum aims to digitize a lot of the artifacts, maps, and memorabilia housed in both historic locations that house the museum. Online exhibits and catalogs of the museum's artifacts would form an online archive and facilitate a wider community impact and draw for the museum.

Socio-Economic Impacts

The Blacksburg Museum and Cultural Foundation enriches and educates visitors about Blacksburg's history, art, and music through exhibitions, showcases, and community events that keep people engaged with their local community and culture.

Local History

According to information from Virginia.org, in the southern and blue ridge highlands region of Virginia, there are only 12 museums dedicated to African American history. The St. Luke & Odds Fellow Hall is one of 3 African American historical sites in Blacksburg entirely. The Blacksburg Museum and Cultural Foundation prioritizes the importance of how history can influence and teach significant aspects of identity, culture, and heritage. It honors important historical events that helped shape and change the community of Blacksburg. This is why the significance of St. Luke & Odd Fellows Hall is an important landmark in African American history within the town of Blacksburg. This building brought the African American community together during a time when discrimination and segregation were prevalent. Restoring and educating others about the significance of this hall will honor their resilience, pride, and overall community spirit while dealing with a time of injustice. Overall, the Blacksburg Museum and Cultural Foundation embraces and respects the history of this township to honor the identity, culture, and heritage of this town.

Art & Music

Exhibitions of live music and art provide artists with exposure, enabling them to experience economic growth through their art. Music and art are key forms of expressing thoughts, feelings, ideas, or themes. Artists want to leave an impact on the audience or listener, inspiring them to

ask questions, share feelings, and engage with their art. This gives artists purpose and passion when creating songs or artworks. This foundation recognizes the importance of revealing ideas and emotions through art to teach an audience. Just one exhibit could teach a person more about a specific topic that they might not know much about. The Blacksburg Museum and Cultural Foundation also focuses on helping local artists by providing more opportunities to showcase their art, revealing the type of art and music that is emerging from the town of Blacksburg.

Community Involvement

Keeping Blacksburg involved in activities this foundation provides keeps the community connected, teaches history, and helps build relationships within the community. One of the many community events hosted by the Blacksburg Museum and Cultural Foundation is Genealogy Saturdays. This event occurs every Saturday, where volunteer genealogists come in and help community members trace their heritage. This provides the opportunity to learn more about identity, culture, and personal history. The foundation also hosts study halls where students can come in and study at the Alexander Black House. These study sessions provide students with ways to connect with others and form new relationships. Overall, the community events held by this foundation allow new relationships within the community to grow and enable people to learn more about each other's histories and art.

Sponsors

The Stateson Homes company has donated and sponsored the Blues, Brew, and BBQ event held by the Blacksburg Museum and Cultural Foundation. Stateson Homes is a company in New River Valley that specializes in homebuilding and buying. The Blues, Brew, and BBQ event is an event held in St. Luke & Odds Fellow Hall that recognizes and showcases New Town, a neighborhood for African Americans residents during segregation. The event highlights the important history as well as remembers the significance of it. With the St. Luke & Odds Fellow Hall being refurbished inside to better fit the needs of a museum space, events like this would be able to occur more and at a higher caliber.

The Shelter Alternatives Incorporated has donated and sponsored the Blacksburgs Museum and Cultural Foundations rotating exhibits. They are a local home-building and home-designing company that have been serving homeowners since 1988. They specialize in sustainability and are well reputable in the Blacksburg area with a 4.6 out of 5 rating on Google Reviews. The rotating exhibits include historical artifacts and art relevant to the history of Blacksburg and provide citizens with accessible and engaging ways of looking at history.

Conclusion

The Blacksburg Museum and Cultural Foundation serves as a space where people can come together to explore the historical significance that shapes the identity, culture, and heritage of this township. The foundation supports local artists and musicians by providing them with exposure and an opportunity to showcase art that inspires and educates, introducing new ideas and concepts to the community. Through a variety of community events and activities, the foundation fosters self-discovery and encourages the creation of new relationships. This commitment to bringing people together is why it is so important for the foundation to expand its exhibits and create interactive experiences that promote a deeper understanding and respect for history. The restoration of St. Luke & Odd Fellows Hall could offer, if given the right funding, a space for learning, connections, self-discovery, embracing culture, and allowing visitors to witness history come to life right before their eyes.

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